Senior Year
2020

The last day before we were sent home
“for a few weeks”
that turned into the rest of our lives,
I ran to my car after class
during lunch, exhilarated,
and pulled out of my spot as cautiously as possible.

I must have just had band
that building was right beside the gravel path
down to the parking lot
and I would never have risked
being late
to my next class otherwise.

But it has been a long year
and I no longer
remember.

Two months before we were sent home,
he sees me on the sidewalk
by the school track
and asks me to wait.

He skids on the same patch of ice
I did.
I don’t warn him.

“Hey,” I say.
How are you,
haven’t died yet?
Good,
glad to hear it.

“Hey,” he says.
This is awkward, but
I’ve started it
and by God

I'm going to lie in it.

Two months and one week before were are sent home,
I'm running up the hill from him
laughing
laughing with one of his friends
without fear.
They must have salted that gravel path up
up to the school.

But again,
I don't remember.

Two months and one week and two days before we were sent home,
on our second date,
there was a mercedes-benz in the parking lot
of the movie theater
and he confused it for a mazda.
At least he knew
mazda.

After he left I sat in my car and watched the streetlights
like modern-day stars.

Two months and two weeks and four days before we were sent home,
on our first date
we sat in a booth in my favorite restaurant.

There was a woman waiting in line,
making progress towards the counter
for a good part
of a quarter
of an hour.

She kept making faces while I spoke
spoke about how I
rarely loved people
hated middle school
had an uncle kidnapped once
refused to show affection

really liked the pasta.

The day before we were sent home,
I ran up the gravel path
the salty taste of chicken tenders on the edges of my lips
and sat
three seats down from him.

We had a sub that day.
She had us act out a scene from Richard II.
Or perhaps it was Henry IV.
Again,
I don't remember.

One of our friends dropped his drone
out the window
and couldn't maneuver it well enough
to get it back through the crack.

One of our friends performed an excellent rendition
of a Welsh accent
and died dramatically
on the carpet floor.

I drank my strawberry milkshake and laughed.

The last hour before we were sent home,
I sat next to my best friend
in International Relations
and glared suspiciously at her when she accused me of being the werewolf.

We laughed too
when the clock struck 3:05 PM
and I won
and we thought we would come back tomorrow
and do it all
again.

Friendship

It might have started on the third day of the school backpacking trip that turned into a camping trip
because of the fires that year
when we were sliding down a slightly muddy trail
hands against the dirt roots of an ancient tree
I asked if, forced to choose, he would make Eurasia or the Americas disappear.

But we were only walking beside each other
because the night before
our entire group had crawled into the boys' tent
and someone told a joke story of a monk and a door
and I told the story of my grandfather and his encounter with a ghost.

But we were only in the same group
because three months before
I had sat on the carpeted floor of the history classroom
and filled in *no health restrictions no dietary restrictions activity level 2*
pencil going through the paper
complaining to my friends about the lack of clipboards.

But I was only in that school
because two years ago
under the infinite sky of a last summer day
in front of the roundabout and its hundred-year-old bell
the director of my academic support camp
which partnered with that school
suggested to my mother that I apply.

But I was only in that camp that year
because five weeks before
my mother had begged the director to let me in again
pulling her aside against the white tile walls
she couldn't afford to pay for summer camp
and I was too young to be left alone.

But I only joined that camp the year before
because my only friend was in it.

And I only had one friend in fifth grade because everyone hated me.

And everyone hated me because I had skipped a grade

and I had skipped a grade because I had already attended kindergarten
and I had already attended kindergarten because I was too young to enroll publicly
and I was too young to enroll publicly because I was born in October and I was born in October
because my parents were married in October

October.
It was October when we passed by each other in the beige hallway
going to classes we don't even remember
among juniors slamming grey locker doors
between groups of freshman girls
I chose to raise my hand
and he chose to wave back.

I, Daughter

Ethics

I *Enduring*
can *consists*
hold *in*
my *resisting*
breath *while*

I *self-*
can *control*
bite *consists*
my *in*
tongue *overcoming*

I *If*
can *that*
stay *is*
awake *what*
for *you*
days *need*

Confessions

I *It*
can *is*
fake *one*
a *thing*
smile *to rise*

I *rapidly*
can *another*
force *thing*
a *not*
laugh *to fall*

I *If*
can *that*

dance *is*
and *what*
play *you*
the *want*
part

Family

I
una niña buena
can
no
turn
puede
it
andar
on
con muchachos

be
u bosni
a
morao sam išli
good
svuda sa mom
machine
sestrom

I
If
can
that
hold
is
the
what
weight
you
of
ask

worlds

Be your number one

I had no motive for my wickedness except wickedness itself

Was it possible to take pleasure in what was illicit for no reason other than that it was not allowed?

Our hearts were tickled to think we were deceiving those who would not think us capable of such behaviour and would have profoundly disapproved

Give you all I am

Justice in this sense, then, is complete virtue, not without qualification, but in relation to another person

The community constituted by man and woman appears aristocratic, since the man rules in accordance with merit and in those areas in which a man should rule; but whatever befits a woman, he places in her hands

I was much inferior to them in greatness of soul

Be your everything

I bleed when I fall down.

I, Aida
My mother called me today
to ask for computer advice
for my father
something about the printer
something about having done it before

and I told her
I am busy
and hung up.

Sometimes I Think of The Past

One of my old classmates was
caught
selling drugs last year,
I tell the nebulous chatter
at the sixth grade girls'
table
in the beige-tiled
cafeteria.

What happened?
Lizzy squeals,
blue-veined right hand on her silver
fork
left hand on her pink cloth
lunchbox.

Can you believe it?
It was on the
second-to-last
day of
fifth grade
the principal showed up
in a navy suit
at the door
of our portable
two policemen
behind him
he left them standing
at the brittle
aluminum doorway
and spoke quietly
to the boy
who walked out
with him,
I respond,
smiling,
hand against my Hello Kitty
container.

My elementary school
in fourth grade
was a hotbed of racial tension,
I tell the boy I like
when we pause in the beige
hallway
in front of my grey
locker
in my new private
school.

What happened?
he follows up
voice confused
pale face naive
hand on his new
macbook pro.

It was after
the bush administration
and worry over
immigration raids
it was a Spanish
immersion school
Latinos against
Americanos,
I explain,
voice off-handed,
tan hand on the textbook
for our algebra II class.

I was bullied pretty badly
in sixth grade,
I tell my new best friends
sitting at the bar in the new bubble tea
place
I had found
after liking a post
of a girl a year younger than me
from middle school

curved glass
jar
overflowing ice
cream
in her hand.

What happened?
inquire Viraj and Megan
watching me out of
the corners
of their eyes
a finger on their plastic
straw
a finger on their facedown
phone.

A girl in my grade was jealous
that I was better at Spanish
than her
so she decided to take it out
on me,
I clarify
hands on the light wooden
table
eyes on the dark pewter
road
a sidestreet too small
for the gentrification
the mayor is putting on it.

One of my old classmates was caught selling drugs
My elementary school in fourth grade was a hotbed of racial tension
I was bullied pretty badly in sixth grade,
I tell my therapist
during the summer between college
and high school
and he dutifully writes
it all down
to ask me

What happened?

I can only remember

Can you believe it? It was on the second-to-last day of fifth grade the principal showed up in a navy suit at the door of our portable two policemen behind him he left them standing at the brittle aluminum doorway and spoke quietly to the boy who walked out with him

It was after the bush administration and worry over immigration raids it was a Spanish immersion school Latinos against Americanos

A girl in my grade was jealous that I was better at Spanish than her so she decided to take it out on me.